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Veiled sentiments

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Meeker and Caton follow this pattern, dealing exclusively with the former type, perhaps because of their interest in the political.²¹ For Meeker, the choice was deliberate. Of the rich corpus of poems available in Musil's collection, he chose to analyze only the poems and narratives of war found in one chapter, ignoring the many love poems and ditties included in another chapter. This choice is indirectly rationalized by Meeker's argument (1979, 26, 94–97) that the Rwala were little concerned with the domestic life of the camp, in contrast to sedentary or semisedentary Middle Eastern peoples. In discussing the domestic life of the camp, Meeker, following Charles Doughty, notes only the *mejilis*, or men's gathering in the chief's tent. Caton, who spent a considerable period doing field research in Yemen, had less choice. He moved almost exclusively in the world of men in this sex-segregated society, tape-recording poems recited by men at formal public occasions, where he was welcomed as a guest among other guests, and interviewing tribal poets. His access to the domestic world of home and intimate gatherings of close friends and relatives was limited.

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The fact that I moved within the intimate world of the Awlad 'Ali, having as a primary research interest neither poetry nor politics but social life, particularly the life of sentiment, certainly has some bearing on the genre of poetry I encountered and found central and on the relationship I ultimately draw between Bedouin poetry and society.²² The *ghinnawa* can be considered the poetry of personal life: individuals recite such poetry in specific social contexts, for the most part private, articulating in it sentiments about their personal situations and closest relationships.

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The most striking thing about the poems recited by Awlad 'Ali men and women I knew was the radical difference between the sentiments expressed in them and those expressed about the same situations in ordinary social interactions and conversations. The Bedouins' propensity to joke about or deny concern in personal matters and to express anger in difficult situations had struck me [■32](#) as defensive. But the constellation of sentiments expressed in their poignant lyric poems, for the most part having to do with vulnerability and deep attachment to others, were ones I could readily appreciate and ones that they too seemed to find moving.

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21. The same can be said of Geertz's (1976) emphasis on agonistic communication and poetic exchanges in Morocco and Sawayan's (1985) focus on men's poetry and politics.

22. It is also possible that Awlad 'Ali place greater emphasis on personal than on heroic poetry, perhaps related to their lesser concern with political adventure under conditions of relative peace and a semisedentary existence based on a combination of pastoralism and agriculture. Meeker (1979, 193–208) suggests just these sorts of differences between the Cyrenaican Bedouin of North Africa (to whom Awlad 'Ali are kin) and the pure pastoral nomads of northern Arabia in the early part of this century. My hypothesis about the changing role of poetry (chapter 8) supports this interpretation.

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